Assagai - Afrorock (SPR 90054)

Assagai were a group of South African and Nigerian musicians working in London. Their line up included drummer Louis Moholo, trumpeter Mongezi Feza, alto saxophonist Dudu Pukwana, tenor saxophonist Bizo Mngqikana, and guitarist Fred Coker.

This record was originally released in 1971 with a different title Zimbabwe and completely different artwork. In 1975, Music for Pleasure reissued it at 49p under a new title: Afrorock. Although the music was unchanged the artwork was not. In place of the original psych-style sleeve was 70s kitschy packaging designed to shift units in the budget racks.

MFP did not typically deal in this kind of material. It was broadening in terms of styles and genre in the 70s but even so this record really does stand out in their catalogue.

The sleeve and title might raise an eyebrow now. Afrorock as a category, the packaging as a whole. It has the feel of music being made approachable for an audience assumed not to be ready for the real thing.

Today, based on Discogs statistics, roughly four times as many people own the MFP pressing as the original. Whether MFP's reissue broadened the audience for Assagai's music or simply reframed it for easier consumption is difficult to separate. Probably both.